

THE LAST PHARAOH OF EGYPT Born c. 68 BCE Died 30 BCE

Cleopatra

“I will not be exhibited in his triumph.”

CLEOPATRA REMARKING ON OCTAVIAN’S VICTORY PARADE, 30 BCE

As a daughter of Ptolemy XII of Egypt, Cleopatra VII belonged to the Ptolemaic Dynasty (see pp.118–19) set up by the first Ptolemy, one of the generals of Alexander the Great (see pp.96–97). In theory, Egypt was independent, but in practice it was controlled by Rome. The Romans supported the Ptolemaic monarchs in return for financial favors. Cleopatra’s father paid enormous sums to secure Roman backing, but this did not prevent Cleopatra’s older sisters Tryphaena and Berenice from plotting against him.

When her father died in 51 BCE, Cleopatra, as eldest surviving daughter, ascended the throne with a younger brother. According to tradition, the king and queen were brother and sister as well as husband and wife, so she was expected to marry her brother, Ptolemy XIII. However, he and his chief minister Pothinus had other ideas—Ptolemy wished to be sole ruler, and by 49 BCE

Cleopatra had been deprived of power and exiled. In 48 BCE, when the

Roman political and military leader Julius Caesar (see pp.108–09) led a military campaign to Egypt, Cleopatra feared for her life. In becoming Caesar’s lover, she was fighting for survival.

Caesar and Caesarion

With the help of reinforcements from Rome, Julius Caesar defeated an Egyptian army led by yet another of Cleopatra’s sisters, Arsinoë IV. During the same campaign, Ptolemy XIII drowned—pulled into the Nile by the weight of his golden armor. Cleopatra was now free to rule Egypt with her youngest brother, Ptolemy XIV. Caesar had returned to Rome when she had their baby, whom she named Ptolemy Caesar, or Caesarion (“little Caesar”). Shortly

Cleopatra as pharaoh

In this relief from a temple at Dendra, Cleopatra is depicted in the style of a pharaoh, wearing the crown of Hathor and a vulture headdress. She holds a staff and an ankh—the sign of life.



Cleopatra and Antony

This silver coin shows Cleopatra (left) on one side and her lover, Roman general Mark Antony (right), on the other.

A legendary beauty

This 19th-century image depicts the glamorous Cleopatra of myth and legend. In reality, her success as a leader and a lover owed more to her intelligence and charm than her looks.

